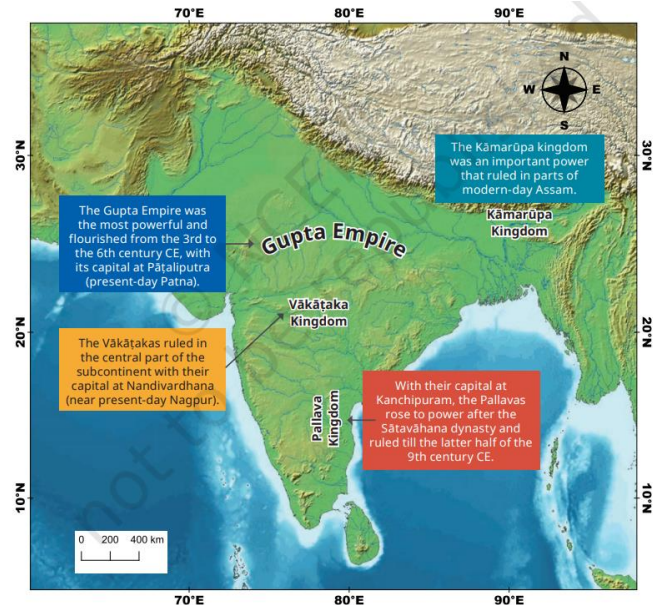


Chapter – 7: The Gupta Era: An Age of Tireless Creativity

Neither force nor mere diplomacy can eliminate evil; nor is righteousness upheld by flattery alone. It is wisdom and knowledge that truly strengthen a kingdom – not indulgence in luxuries. — Kālidāsa in *Raghuvansham*

- Dhruv, Bhavisha – just returned – their journey – Pandya kingdom – splendid markets – short trip on ship – met Roman traders – buying pearls
- Now wanted – use *Itihasa* – jump few cent. – soon whisked away – Gupta Empire
 - Bhavisha – so confused – so many kingdoms – how to remember
 - Dhruv – don't worry – understand what's happening – remember it
 - Bhavisha – wonders – anything – this period – back home
 - Dhruv – let's use time machine – find out
- Bhavisha – activates *Itihasa* – jump to – Mehrauli (Delhi)
- Overhear – tour guide – explaining importance – Iron pillar
 - Tour guide – Iron pillar – 1600 yrs. old – stands tall – no rust – adv. metallurgical skills – ancient India
 - Bhavisha – wonders – so old – still no rust – let's see it
 - Dhruv – wonders – something written – not readable
 - Bhavisha – wonders – purpose of this pillar – wants to hear – tour guide's view
 - Tour guide – Iron pillar – 6-tonne – reign of Chandragupta II – probably 1st – *Udayagiri* caves (M.P.) – brought to Delhi – few cent. later – dedicated to Vishnu – inscriptions – celebrate king's achievements
 - Both – very fascinated – lets learn more



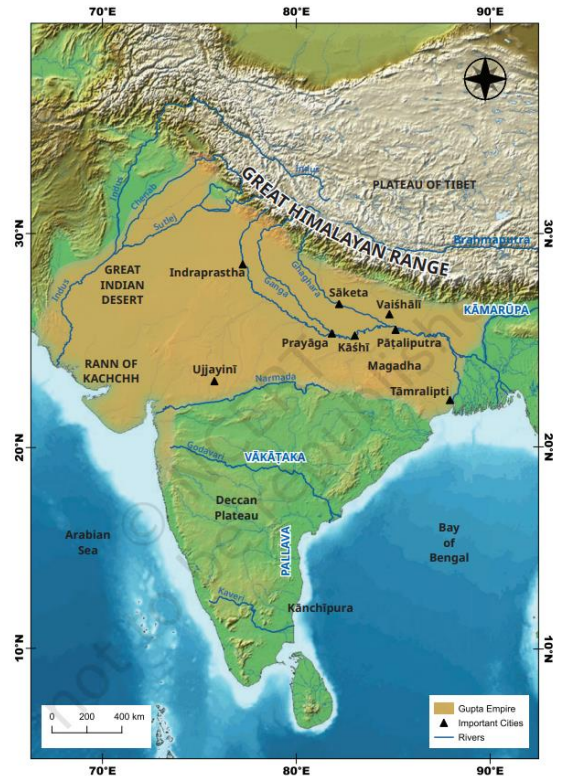
A New Power Emerges

- 3rd cent. CE – Kushana Empire – started to weaken
- New kingdom appeared – fresh period – new dynasty – Guptas
- Various theories – origin – Guptas – widely believed – started – Uttar Pradesh – regional rulers
- Over time – powerful empire
- Gupta period – considered remarkable – significant developments
- Fields – art, architecture, literature, science – flourished – particularly – Chandragupta II
- Inscription – iron pillar (Delhi) – king – Chandra – identified as – Chandragupta II – do not confuse – Chandragupta Maurya – Maurya dynasty
- Chandragupta II – also known – Vikramaditya – renowned ruler – Gupta dynasty – devotee – Vishnu – Garuda – appears – many inscriptions

The warrior king

- *Prayaga prashasti* – pillar inscription – Prayagraj – praises – Samudragupta – Chandragupta II's father
- Author – court poet Harisena – king's ambition – *dharani-bandha* – unify earth

- Samudragupta – many wars – expanding empire
- Some defeated kings – reinstated – offered tribute – others – submitted – without protest
- Harisena – also wrote – king – support art, learning, trade – making kingdom – rich, successful
- Samudragupta – portrayed – veena player – minted coins
- Some literary src. – descriptive info. – rulers, kingdoms, people
- *Vishnu purana* – specifies – key regions – empire – Gupta dynasty – will rule –
 - Anuganga (middle-gangetic basin)
 - Prayag (Prayagraj)
 - Saketa (Ayodhya)
 - Magadha (Bihar)
- BUT – its peak – Gupta Empire – larger area – north, west, central, east India
- Whole army – soldiers, elephants, horses, cooks, other staff, supplies – tributary kings – provided for these



Traveller's Account of Indian Society in the Gupta Age

- Chinese traveller – Faxian – visited India – early 5th cent. CE
- This long, difficult – journey – visit Buddhist sites – learn from Indian scholars – collect manuscripts – Buddhist texts
- Faxian – travelled India – obs. culture, governance, society – recorded everything – his travelogue – survived till date
- Excerpts – historical accounts – Faxian's – valuable src. – BUT – reflect – writer's perspective – focus – 1 pt. in time
- Faxian – also describes – harsh treatment – *chandalas* – outcastes – living outside the city limits
- Grp. of historians – examine same src. – varied interpretations – check out more src.
- This reminds – need to access – multiple src. – before conclusions

Glimpses of the Gupta Empire

Governance and administration

- Obs. – map – previous figure – many kingdoms – coexisted – same period
- Some of them – war – each other – expand control
- Recall – Kautilya's ideas – ruling kingdom – advise rulers – form alliances (*mitra*) – one of the components – *saptanga*
- Gupta rulers – various strategies – military, diplomacy, alliances – expand – vast empire
- Last method – matrimonial alliances – example – Prabhavati Gupta – daughter – Chandragupta II – married to Vakataka prince – neighbours to south
- Vakataka prince – died early – Prabhavati Gupta – temp. ruler
- Her reign – ensure – ties – Vakatakas, Guptas – remained strong
- One inscription – describe her – mother of 2 kings – referring – 2 sons – ascended – Vakataka throne
- A devotee of Vishnu – like father – construct – 7 temples – dedicated – this god, his avatars – Ramgiri

- Gupta empire – well-organised – sys. – administration
- Instead of controlling – central authority – divided empire – provinces – granted land – local rulers, priests, chieftains
- Land grants – inscribed – copper plates – accurate records – many – discovered by archaeologists
- This sys. – ensure proper tax collection – easy governance – local rulers – some control

Thriving trade

- Primary src. – revenue – land tax – other src. – fines, tax on mines, irrigation, trade, crafts
- This revenue – used – administration, army, temples, infrastructure, artists, scholars
- Vast empire – sustain – internal, external trade – req.
- Gupta era – Indian trade – Mediterranean world, Southeast Asia, China – export textiles, spices, ivory, gemstones
- Indian ocean trade network – connect – Indian ports – distant markets
- One imp. stop – Mediterranean market – Socotra Island – located – Arabian Sea
- Archaeological evidence – pottery, inscriptions (Brahmi script), Buddhist *stupa* – established presence – Indian traders – several cent. – along with – Egypt, Arabia, Rome, Greece traders
- Small island – evidence – rich cultural exchange

New Ideas and Wonders – The Classical Age

- Gupta rulers – followers of Vishnu – often reflected – coins, inscriptions – also supported – other traditions, schools of thought
- Supported – Buddhist institutions – Nalanda university, other Buddhist *viharas* (monasteries)
- Prolonged period – peace, stability – Gupta period – notable achievements – various fields – historians – labelled as – classical age
- This time – knowledge – previous eras – compiled – numerous texts
- Sanskrit texts – flourished – Kalidasa's work, major *puranas*
- Aryabhata, Varahamihira – major advancements – mathematics, astronomy – medical texts – compiled – refined – medical theories
- Metallurgy – flourished – rust-resistant Iron pillar
- This stability – strengthen economy – support scholars, artists, scientists – cultural, intellectual growth
- Chandragupta II – surrounded himself – learned men, poets, artists – enriched court
- Aryabhata –
 - Lived – Kusumapura – famous centre – learning – 500 CE – authored – short series – mathematics, astronomy – *Aryabhatiya*
 - Gave formulas – calculate motions – sun, moon, planets – proposed – Earth – spins on its axis – explaining alternations – day and night
 - Length of year – 365 days 6 hours 12 minutes 30 seconds – modern day length – 365 days 5 hours 48 minutes 15 seconds
 - Also provided – fair estimate – size of earth – correct explanation – solar, lunar eclipses
 - His work – foundation – further scientific advances – India and beyond
 - Mathematics – Aryabhata described – no. of tech. – calculation, equation solving – some – you learn in school
- Varahamihira –
 - Mathematician, astronomer, astrologer – same period
 - Lived – Ujjayini – famous – tradition – learning, scholarship

- Encyclopedic work – *Brihat Samhita* – wide range – subjects – astronomy, astrology, weather forecasting, architecture, town planning, farming
- His ability – obs. world – apply logical reasoning – combine with – traditional knowledge
- Kalidasa –
 - Little known – Kalidas's life – legends – ridiculed by others – motivated him – work hard, transform life
 - Renowned for contributions – Sanskrit literature, refined poetry
 - Celebrated compositions – *Meghadutam* – cloud messenger – story – *yaksha* (minor deity) – banished from his home – send message – his beloved – passing cloud
 - Apart from emotions of love – poem describes – great detail – landscapes, weather – north India

The Quest for Beauty

- Gupta rulers – supportive env. – creativity, craftsmanship thrived – some – iconic works – this period
- Many key centres of art – emerged –
 - Sarnath – exquisite sculptures – Buddha – near Varanasi
 - Ajanta caves – Maharashtra
 - Udayagiri – Madhya Pradesh – rock cut caves, detailed carvings – deities
- Gupta art – set standards – high – aesthetics, beauty – lasting effect

The Decline of Guptas

- 6th cent. CE – Gupta empire – signs of decline – later rulers – faced challenges – external invasions
- Huna tribe – central Asia – attacked empire – weakening control – north India
- Same time – rise – powerful regional rulers – internal conflicts

Meanwhile in the South and Northeast

- Guptas – ruled north – Pallavas – emerged – powerful dynasty – south – Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh
- Origins – not known – appear to be – tributary power – under Satavahanas – gained power – Satavahanas' decline
- Pallavas – great patrons – art, architecture
- Most of them – devotees – Shiva – credited – construct magnificent temples, rock-cut caves
- Capital of Pallavas – Kanchipuram – city of 1000 temples – major centre of learning – south
- Establishment of *ghatikas* – centres of learning – emerged – reign of Satavahanas – fostered environment – education, intellectual growth
- Northeastern region – Kamarupa kingdom – Varman dynasty – extended over Brahmaputra valley, northeastern parts – Bengal, Bangladesh
- Ancient name – Brahmaputra valley – Assam – Pragjyotisha – mentioned in Ramayana, Mahabharata
- Mahabharata – mentions – Bhagadatta – king of Pragjyotisha – fighting along Kauravas – some rulers – claimed him – their ancestors
- Kamarupa kingdom – prominent cultural, political centre – temples, monasteries – flourished – hubs of learning
- Pallavas, Kamarupa – mentioned – *prayaga prashasti*

- Southern campaigns – Samudragupta defeated – Pallava ruler – did not take over – let local kings – keep thrones – accept his rule, pay tribute – helped – peaceful relations
- Similar conditions – northeast – Samudragupta – defeated ruler of Kamarupa – did not take control
- Gupta period – time – remarkable progress – influence – spread – beyond empire – shaping – art, science, literature, governance – cent.
- Advances – mathematics, astronomy, medicine, metallurgy – laid foundation – future science, tech growth
- Guptas – stable, prosperous society – model – future rulers